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Arturo Sandoval

Arturo Sandoval has become a global figure in the jazz world through his stellar trumpet playing and charismatic stage presence. He augments his solo recordings with numerous guest appearances, and he has expanded his talents to classical compositions and film scoring.

Arturo was interviewed via Zoom on June 12, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and it's a real privilege to have Arturo Sandoval with me this morning. Thank you very much for joining me.

AS: My pleasure, thank you.

MR: And I want to congratulate you on your career and your life in music and what you've added to jazz and classical music here in America.

AS: Thank you sir. I appreciate it.

MR: I'd like to start out with something quite current. I've been watching your FaceBook channel for a while and I took note of a delightful recent song of yours that you put up and I'll see if I can — it's called "Gracias Republica Dominicana."

AS: It's one of them. There's hundreds of them.

MR: So I found it really fascinating, for one thing there's like I don't know six or seven or eight of you on the screen at the same time.

AS: Yeah. It's a little application that I've been using. It's very limited, very hard because you cannot punch in, you cannot edit anything, you cannot tune anything, you know whatever you do is what it is. If you don't like what you did you have to rewind and start from scratch again.

MR: Well that kind of makes you a little more aware of what you're playing, doesn't it? It's like —

AS: It's challenging you know.

MR: Yes. But there was a moment in that, for our listeners I hope they go and check it out because you've got like four or five horn parts going on and I liked it when you were improvising because you literally in the other screens were listening to yourself. And you looked happy about it.

AS: Yeah you know sometimes when I like what the other guy did I smile. If I don't like it I say oh oh.

MR: Which brings me to last night I was listening to your Second Trumpet Concerto and I know that this is maybe not a major part of what you do but I really enjoyed the piece.

And I had a couple of questions about it. First of all when you decided to write another trumpet concerto, did you decide partly because the first one was successful?

AS: I have a question. Where you listened to that? Because I never recorded the second one.

MR: I believe it's a YouTube with a young man, you weren't playing it, a young man playing it.

AS: Oh Ruben Simeo oh yeah he played it several times. Yes. But you know unfortunately we had everything ready to do a recording here in L.A. and then the beginning of the pandemic started and everything got screwed up.

MR: Well did you decide that it was going to be three movements when you started it or is that something that happens along the way?

AS: I'm going to tell you something. The first one I recorded with the London Symphony in Abbey Road Studio years ago. And the first one I wrote a little piece for one of my book, it's supposed to be like a second movement, like a slow movement of a theme, as a sample, and I included it in the book. And I was doing a recording of that at home and my wife asked me, "What is that?" And I explained to her and she said, "Okay. Now start writing the first and the third." I said, "What!" "Yeah. Now — you have the second already. Go ahead and write the first and the third." I said, "Oh come on." She said, "Yes, do it." My wife, you know we call her the "Big Boss." We are married for 48 years you know.

MR: That's marvelous.

AS: And then I said, "Okay, I'm going to try." I did it and then I recorded it. And with the second one it was exactly the same thing.

MR: Did you start with the second movement?

AS: Yes I wrote a piece and then I recorded it here at home you know and she said, "Wow, that sounds like a second movement of a concerto. Okay. You know what you have to do, I don't have to tell you again." The second one is more simple to be honest. It's more melodic. It's not very technical and it's not very complicated at all. Because to be honest, I'm not a big fan of those kind of trumpet concertos, the modern music that has no melodies [scats]. I say wow, I cannot repeat that in my dreams, or I cannot memorize those melodies and harmonies and themes, because I love very much melodic music. My favorite composer is Sergei Rachmaninoff. You know. And then I'm crazy about Debussy and Ravel and Satie, and those people who write — Chopin — all those people who write beautiful, beautiful melodies. They are my heroes you know. And that's what I'm trying to do in almost all my compositions you know. I'm trying to be melodic and kind of — it's always a little bit of romanticism involved in what I do.

MR: I would totally agree and it was so melodic, the third movement of this second concerto, that I pulled out some staff paper and I decided to do what I fifty some years ago had to

do in music school and that was write down your opening of the third movement. So if you'll bear with me, you can be my professor to see how I did. Because let me see — [scats] and then back to the [scats]. And I was like oh, that's so lovely.

AS: Thank you sir, thank you, thank you. You know it's something easy to remember, as you can see, and it has a simple line, just changing the chord underneath and I'm doing some counter line and things to develop the first idea.

MR: Well it surely works and somewhere in there you wrote a finger-buster of a first violin solo. Do you remember that part?

AS: Yeah. It's like a cadenza. For the concert master. Yeah. You know I hear Ruben playing it in Europe and some of the violin players did it okay. Some, very few, did it well. And the others they're the worst. Because they cannot take it for granted, you know, they have to spend a few minutes practicing that cadenza. Yeah. If they practice it and get it down it's okay. But you know in a way, when I wrote it I talked to a couple of good, good violin players here in town and I consulted them about it, that it was playable. Is this something the violin could do. They said absolutely, it's just a matter of spending some time and really getting it down.

MR: Yeah that's one of the big challenges of writing for orchestras is knowing what instruments can actually pull off and you have to do a little bit of research and of course talking to people like that is very helpful. I want to see if we can get rid of the — there's feedback happening on my end so could you go back to that audio setting page.

AS: Did you hear some "oooooo?"

MR: Yes. That's what I'm hearing.

AS: It's a problem I'm having with my mixer over here. If I turn it off, if I turn the mixer off I cannot hear the speaker and then I'm going to be without sound.

MR: I see. Can you turn it down a little bit?

AS: You mean the volume?

MR: Yes.

AS: That's not a problem. You turn it off or on.

MR: Okay.

AS: Sorry. I can switch to the telephone?

MR: You mean doing the interview on the telephone?

AS: Yeah it's the same thing with the telephone and then I can turn off the mixer.

MR: Let's see what that looks like.

AS: Okay. Let me turn this off first. Hold on one second.

MR: Yep.

AS: Let me go to the Email, because I have to get something. Bear with me please.

[gap]

MR: Okay.

AS: Okay? Do you hear me now?

MR: I can. And it's better.

AS: Yeah but I need to put the speaker on. Okay?

MR: Yes. Ut oh.

AS: Oh no because we are — okay?

MR: Yeah. Perfect. Okay. And we can edit out those couple of minutes there.

AS: Okay.

MR: Excellent. So are you a man who likes down time? I know that's kind of a strange question but I get the sense that your head is constantly filled with music.

AS: You know what I always say, music saved my life. Music saved my life. And I owe everything to the music.

MR: Well that sums it up then.

AS: Yeah and then it's my — I mean my appreciation toward the music because when I was young man I grew up in the middle of nowhere of the countryside of the island of Cuba. My family was really poor. And I really was a kind of a hopeless kid. And then because of music my life changed completely and you know I've been blessed because of the music I traveled all over the world and I've been able to give a decent life to my family and raise my kid and now my son is doing great, he's very successful, he's very happy about his career and what he's doing. He's a graphic artist. And you know I have a lot of reason to be grateful to the music.

MR: It's very interesting that musicians from countries other than America who get turned on to jazz, they seem, as you eloquently said, that it's such a big part of your life and the struggles that you took to get there, I wonder if you appreciate it more than many American musicians?

AS: I don't think — hold on one second, bear with me, one second. Let me put the speaker on Bluetooth. Hold on, hold on.

MR: Whatever you did just then made the video problematic.

AS: I think now I'm connected. Talk to me please.

MR: Yes. Okay. I think that yes, we're back on, yeah.

AS: Okay. Perfect.

MR: Okay. Excellent. So we were talking about the struggles that you go through to arrive at a place in the music and you were talking about, you know, your travails and your life to get there.

AS: Yeah. I'm going to tell you, it's not easy to, when you're a Latino person like me to really develop your career, especially in the classical or jazz music, because a lot of people are of a stereotype mentality and then when they hear you speaking or the color of

your skin or whatever, where you come from, they always associate you with the music of your country where you was born you know. And this is not fair. It is not fair at all. Because music is the only international language you know. It belongs to all human beings. It doesn't matter where you was born or grew up you know. If you embrace the music and you really have a big passion and you develop some skill and some things, because you have dedication and you are disciplined, it should be recognized you know. I'll give you an example. It's funny that I've been reading all those magazines specializing in jazz, for example like *DownBeat* or a jazz magazine, all the things. When they put a list of jazz trumpeters I never appear in any of those kind of lists. They ignore me. Okay modesty apart, I laugh all the way to the bank no matter what. But it's hard, because you say man I'm playing music for 62 years. I'm 74 now and I started playing music professionally when I was 12 years old, which means I'm playing music for 62 years non-stop you know, with a lot of passion, dedication, discipline, respect for the music and respect for the audience. And some people don't believe that you deserve some kind of recognition, that's your problem you know. I try as much as I can to do things that don't affect my little brain you know. And what I do is keep practicing and trying to improve and trying to fix things that I feel I haven't been doing maybe in the best way and then this has been my life for so many, many years you know. And I'm going to be like this until I retire or die I don't know.

MR: You said something just in passing there, that you have, part of what you do involves respect for the audience. And I wonder if the reason that you don't show up, especially in the critics' poll, is partly because of that. In other words there's an entertainment part of your performances which is inviting to people, and sometimes critics feel like oh that's not really artistic. That's a little too much show business.

AS: Okay. If they believe so that's their problem. My intention is to make the people have a good time. And you know a famous pianist, I'm not going to name his name, it's not necessary, but he posted something a couple of days [inaudible] in that what he said: people nowadays in the jazz music — exactly, I'm quoting — he's a famous jazz pianist. He said people nowadays play with their head but not with the soul. And I said you know I was tempted to reply to that. I said you shouldn't generalize you know. You shouldn't put everything on everybody in the same sack because that's not fair. But sometimes in a certain way he's right because a lot of jazz musicians make it so complicated nowadays and so technical and so intricate that avoids to gain a lot more people who appreciate, understand and follow jazz music. And that's one of the things I'm not looking for. I don't want to impress the people. I want the people to have a good time. And leave the place with the desire to come back when I get back in town. That's the way to make our business survive.

MR: I don't know if you'll be able to address this or not but do you think that playing with the head more than the soul is partly an outcome of the boom in jazz education?

AS: I'm going to tell you something. We have another problem which is even deeper and more — it's worse than that. I strongly believe that we have a serious problem, especially in the U.S. with the appreciation and promoting, defending, protecting the immense legacy that we got in our culture about jazz. We don't feel like that kind of appreciation in general terms. I'm talking about the radio stations, the television, the media in general. We don't have a little bit of support. I'm going to tell you something. I'm living in the U.S. for 34 years and I consider it a crime that I never saw one minute of jazz on television. I'll repeat that. I consider that a crime because if you go to Scandinavia or Japan or anywhere, even in Europe, all over Europe, on Saturday night, to put an example, on Saturday night at 9 P.M. you're going to have a good chance to watch on the main network two hours of any of those jazz festivals around the world. I never saw that in the U.S. and I repeat, that's a crime because it's our mission, it's our obligation to preserve that immense legacy that jazz music means to the American culture. And I'm going to add something. I strongly believe that jazz music is the most important contribution from the U.S. to the art to the world. Some people, no, most of the people don't get it. And that's something unacceptable. It's something horrible, horrible. Because I always think about what they think — Louis Armstrong and Dizzy, and all those people — they are looking from the sky and they said, "Guys, what the heck are you doing with what we left you? Are you protecting this? Are you defending that? Are you promoting? Are you proud of that? Are you?" They have that question and they ask that question to us every day. And what is the reaction of the media? They promote the trashy music. The trash. You know the worst thing. And the thing that the younger generation is getting about music is not the best one. It's probably the worst. And in terms of the lyrics for example nowadays a lot of songs they are so full of profanity you know. They say a bunch of dirty words and the younger listen to this like that's normal, that's okay, that's the today music. No. That's not today's music. That's trash music. That's something horrible that we should feel ashamed for that. And I'm still waiting, I hope someday before I die I see some reactions from the media to educate the people and let them know what jazz means and how much jazz music is appreciated all over the world. A lot more than the U.S., in the U.S.

MR: It's a conundrum because you have almost every university in the country now, I don't know if it's because it was an artistic decision but more than likely it was a financial decision that having a jazz program was something that they decided to do because they could see that there would be students who would come to their colleges. Yet as you say the respect for the music generally has not kept up with that.

AS: Yes. And I back up my word and I strongly believe what I said. Otherwise I don't say it. And a lot of music, in general, programs out of the schools in general has been cut. You know that. And that's another problem. Because music, the only thing it does is create better human beings and make the brain to function a little bit more human and more intelligent and more — how can I say — able to be more compassionate and better quality of person in general. That's the only thing the music does. Music fills your heart and your soul with good emotion and things and then you feel motivated, you feel like wow, this is great you know. And when you have the experience to play an instrument and participate in any kind of formation, it's a privilege and also it's a wonderful experience. It's a wonderful experience. And then we must support music programs in every school, from kindergarten to college, the university or whatever — what they should do. Another thing I'm going to mention to you, I don't know if you are aware but I'm going to mention something that's very strange. Most of the governments around the world within the government they have a Minister of Culture. We don't have it in the U.S. Are you aware of that?

MR: I am.

AS: Yes. We don't have it. We don't have anybody within the government that represents the art in general and defend and protect and promote the art and I don't get it. This is a country, we're supposed to be the role model of the world in every sense, and we have to take care of that. When Winston Churchill was asked during the Second War, why are you spending so much money promoting and sending artists to the troops and all this kind of thing. And he said, "If we don't protect that and promote that why are we fighting for?" Wow. I'm a big fan of Winston Churchill by the way. I think he was a brain. He was an incredible guy.

MR: He was. I love reading about him.

AS: Great personality, very smart, very eloquent, and a guy with great ideas. He was a gentleman. And also, he smoked cigars like me too.

MR: Can I call you a cigar aficionado?

AS: Big time.

MR: Yeah that's a first for us.

AS: I started smoking cigars 60 years ago, when I was 14 years old.

MR: Well consistency pays off.

AS: Every freaking day. My hero, Dizzy Gillespie, also smoked cigars.

MR: Thank you for wearing that tee shirt by the way.

AS: Oh I love it, man. A good friend of mine took a photo that I have here in my studio, I can show you, I've got a photo here, exactly this photo, and he took a photo of that and from

that made a couple of these for me. And I'm so happy to wear it you know. Because that guy meant a lot to me.

MR: Mike Longo, who I got to interview, said something that I took note of. He said, "In our music, rhythm and melody are almost the same. Dizzy used to use the term 'melodization of rhythm.'" And I think what he meant by that is Dizzy was hearing rhythms and putting pitches to it.

AS: He also said, "Improvising is like painting on the canvas" you know. You mix the color, you create shades and this and that. It's like you're creating — you have to imagine the whole picture in your mind when you are improvising. It's like creating a speech for something. A good speech in America they start, "Good evening ladies and gentlemen, here we are" la-la-la-la. But we have some issue that we have to talk about and then they start changing the tone, the volume, [inaudible] at the end they wrap. And they say "We keep hope in that God's going to help us to put it together and everything. Thank you so much for coming here tonight. Good night." It's like you know it's an art form. It's an art form. It's like a poem you know.

MR: I wonder if you landed on something that goes back to what we were talking about as far as America respecting the art form in that what you're just describing takes some investment from the listener. It's the fact that there's no — you know jazz is mostly an instrumental music and people need to be able to use their imagination to enjoy it, and perhaps we're getting lazy and finding that that's too much work.

AS: Yeah because jazz is not elevator music. It's something you have to concentrate when you listen, and you can establish a kind of conversation thing pretending that you will understand what's going on on stage or in a recording or whatever. You have to pay attention and you have to try to follow what they're doing and what the artist are sharing with us. And if you don't do that jazz is — one more time, it's not elevator music. It's not a background music. It's not something that you put there when you're having dinner and forget about it at a very low volume. No, no. That's not jazz music. It's like going to the concert hall and listening to Mozart or Chopin or Stravinsky. You can't establish a conversation in Carnegie Hall, meanwhile you listen to a concerto. This is exactly the same thing. And also, talking about support, the few poor stations that play jazz, they are community radio, very small, with a very short antenna and, you know, the reach they got is very poor and local. As soon as you move a little bit away from the station you lost the signal. That's another crime. Because the trash music got a huge antenna. And you can listen all over. And you can listen very easy everywhere. But it's another thing you know. They don't spend resources in promoting our beloved music style.

MR: Let me ask you about your improvising. I ask this question fairly often — what's going on in your head. We were just talking about the brain and soul and can you describe

what's going on in your head when you're — like I was watching one of the many recordings or videos of your "Funky Cha-Cha." And you're playing these very intense bebop lines and so forth and I'm wondering what's going on up there?

AS: You know let's rewind sixty years and I'm going to tell you — I started in my village, because I grew up in the village in the countryside of the island. I started playing traditional Cuban music with local bands, that was the first thing. And then I went to school later on to get classical training and I spent three years in that school, strictly classical. In that school, that was funny, we weren't allowed to play, talk or listen to anything but classical music. It was like a military kind of thing. And then already I was playing for a few years but I never heard any jazz. And then one day a guy who was a journalist and a writer, he was a journalist, he talked to me and said, "Hey, you ever hear the jazz music?" And I say, "What is that?" He said, "Come with me, I'm going to play something for you." And he played for me a vinyl, you know it was a compilation of recordings from the 40s from Dizzy Gillespie and Charlie Parker. That was the very first thing I ever heard about. And I will never forget that moment. It's still in my mind for sixty years or more— I'm sorry — less than sixty years because I was already like 18, 19 years old and I never heard any jazz before at all. And that thing impressed me so much that I couldn't speak. You know I was — you know I said oh my Lord, what the heck those people are playing? This is what you call jazz? He said yes, yes. Man, I wanted to learn that. I don't know how or when but I want to learn that. And I'm still on a mission after so many years. I'm still on a mission. And we're never going to reach the end in terms of learning. I believe you know it's our mission to keep listening, paying attention, investigating, and keep trying to improve what you do. If you believe that you have reached some point already it's like the famous phrase "sleeping in your laurels" you know. And that's not smart. That's not smart. Because that means the end of your growing process. And the growing process is something that you don't have any end, only with your death.

MR: You just answered one of the questions I had written down, so thank you. Does the fact that you play piano impact your trumpet improvising?

AS: Big time, and a great question. That was, after I listened to that, later on I got in my hands one of those jazz history books. And in one of the chapters of that book it was the story of Miles Davis came to Dizzy Gillespie asking him for help to get into the more deeper concept of improvisation and knowledge of the changes and all those things. And Dizzy said, "Okay I can help you. Let's go to the piano." And Miles said, "Piano? What?" Dizzy said, "Okay, that's the only way I can explain it to you." When I read that, hold on let me close the door because my wife is start talking. And when I read that I said uh oh, I think that's a good lesson, not only for Miles, that's good for everyone. And then that

really made that thing into my brain and I said you know what? I have to get familiar with the piano. And I never regret it. By the way, I spend a lot more time with the piano than with the trumpet. Because the piano for composition, for arranging, for creating, for understanding the chord sequencing and the basis, not only the basis but only all the variation and a tentative chord that you can find, and the piano has something else that is you can hear the thing but you can see. You understand what I mean? With the trumpet you cannot see anything. You have to imagine everything — or clarinet or a saxophone or whatever. But with the piano you can see the notes that belongs to the chord and what are the changes you can do with that and what are the scales that belongs to that specific chord. And then that gives you a better control, a better conscious of how to handle those chord changes.

MR: That's a terrific observation. Because I play saxophone and piano and I noticed that sometimes if I see, you know, talking about notes that are outside the scale, playing outside a little bit. And you're right, there's a visual dimension to it, you know?

AS: Out. They call it out.

MR: They call it out, man.

AS: You know something funny, one day in one of my hundreds of conversations with my hero and mentor John Birks Gillespie, that's his real name, because I never would agree with that nickname of Dizzy because he was anything but Dizzy. He was a really smart guy. He was a genius and creator of a complete different style of music. But I asked him, "Dizzy, please explain to me those weird notes that you play within the chord?" And he looked at me and said, "I don't call that weird. I call it funny notes." And I'm going to share with you another trick that I've been doing for many, many, many years. When I want to learn a specific tune I learn the chords first on the piano. But instead of playing in the piano one key down, I learn it in the trumpet key. That helps me as well. Because when I'm improvising I remember not only the chord but the notes that I was playing in the same key. I don't have to transpose, you understand what I mean? It's easier.

MR: So you're playing "My Funny Valentine" in D minor on the piano, so that when you go to play the trumpet you're there?

AS: Actually no, in E minor.

MR: Right but I mean normally that tune is in C minor I think so —

AS: Oh you're right, you're right, yeah. Uh, I don't know, [plays trumpet] you're right. It's C minor. But I learned it in D minor on the piano. Yes.

MR: Does your trumpet playing end up sort of this reversal like do you do things on the trumpet and say oh, I should try that on the piano?

AS: Oh absolutely. It's a two way, it's a two way thing of course. Your element — one thing — and the other one, you know, you have to, in the end, it's a way to create your speech

you know. And the way to gather your ideas that makes sense. I have some melodic — some people for example, they believe when you're playing fast you are throwing notes. That's a stupid mistake. We don't throw in notes. For something, and the way we learn solfeggio, we name it, every name of the notes. We don't say do-re-me da-ba-da — no no. We say do-re-mi-fa-sol-la-ti-do [continues to scat quickly]. When I'm playing fast, very fast, some people criticize, yeah okay. And I always, my response to that is I would love to play the trumpet in the way Michael Brecker played the tenor or Oscar Peterson played the piano. That's my goal, my heroes, the people who are or on their way — Neils-Henning Orsted Pederson plays the acoustic bass. He is my hero in terms of the bass. My hero. And some people want you to play just for example imitating other great musicians. If you put a mute on they want you sound like Miles. If you sound different they don't give credit and they don't really appreciate it. I say man, to be a copy of the original is the most stupid thing.

MR: Say that again.

AS: To copy, to be a bad copy of the original is a very stupid idea. Our goal should be to express ourselves in the way you feel. In the way, you know, and also modesty apart, if you have been practicing for so many years, for so millions of hours, it's to develop skill. To do what? Because there's two ways when you're a professional musician. You play what you want, or you play what you can. I swear, I want to belong to the first group. I want to play in the way I want. You could do that. What you have to do: control your instrument, be in control. Spend millions of hours practicing to develop the skill and to have that preparation to play your instrument in the way you feel and the way you want, without struggling with frustration and limitations. Some people don't get it. If I play something, for example "If I Do"

[audio interlude]

Let me repeat that

[audio interlude]

I am completely conscious of what I was doing. I wasn't throwing notes. No. I know the name of every note, and I know the reason of every note. Why I play.

MR: Why you play it. Because were you —

AS: Because it's a kind of line, melodical. It's a kind of line that I like it because it's in the tradition of bebop or jazz in general, and also I know those notes belong and work well with the chord.

MR: I heard you say a phrase in an interview, "You should play pretty, anybody can play ugly."

AS: It's easy to play ugly.

MR: What does that mean?

AS: I, you know, because some people they're not concentrating on certain things. The first thing we must care about is the quality of the tone, the quality of the sound. We must produce a good sound, in tune and warm and pretty and good sound. That's the number one priority. But also I recommend my students for example, to listen to good singers. And even some old timers are recommended, to learn the lyrics of a song. You understand what I mean? There's two different ways to play a melody.
[audio interlude "When I Fall in Love"]

MR: Okay I think that qualifies as ugly.

AS: Yes. Absolutely. But if you think about how for example Nat King Cole or Ella Fitzgerald would sing that, you'd rewind and say let me try it again.
[audio interlude "When I Fall in Love"]
You're singing, you understand what I mean? You're even making implicit the lyrics even if you're playing instrumental.

MR: I had a question here that I wrote down and it was, was your vibrato influenced by hearing particular singers?

AS: Absolutely. Some of them doing this:
[audio interlude plays "When I Fall in Love" straight and with vibrato
You see what I mean? They start like this, flat, and then toward the end of the note they start accelerating a little bit, the vibrato. It's a different way. You know some of the classical players or some other people they're very fond of another kind of playing. They don't like to use vibrato at all. I've been criticized because of the vibrato. And I said man, vibrato is part of your expression. It's part of the nuance of the saying within the note. You know also when you use a little vibrato you have a much better possibility to be in tune.

MR: That's true.

AS: Because when you're playing completely flat, you have to be very careful that you hit that note exactly in the center of the pitch. But this is the line of the pitch over here. When you do vibrato you're doing this — and you have a good possibility to be around the center of the pitch you know. I don't conceive a singer for example [sings without expression] When I fall in love." I don't get it. I don't get it. It's something missing there, internal expression and the best thing we could do as an instrumentalist is to copy a good singer.

MR: Also can you imagine a string section not using vibrato what that would sound like.

AS: The pitch is going to be horrible to start with. Yes. Yes.

MR: A couple of more questions. Back to your improvising. Have you — I know I've seen transcriptions of your solos. And I wonder if, you probably have as well, are you able to play them if you wanted to after they've been written out?

AS: Oh. Yeah. I used to be a very good sight reader you know. And as I practiced it, yeah, I used to be able to do it. It's always — you know what, I'll never forget, one time that I get together with Dizzy after traveling to somewhere. I copied one of the transcriptions of one of his solos. And I said, and I showed it to him, I said, "Diz, look at this man." And he said, "What the heck is that?" I said, "It's something transcribed, a kind of trumpet solo. You think that's possible to play?" He said, "Hell no, that's impossible." I said, "Diz, that was your solo. That was your solo, man." He said, "No kidding."

MR: But when you just a couple of minutes ago you were doing the solfeggio and you were moving your — you weren't playing the piano, you were moving your trumpet fingers. Okay. Do you think that —

AS: Let me use another tool that I got here, because I got different ones you know, I've got different ones with different — hold on one second. Yes, I've got another horn here which is a lot larger. The bell, the bore, they're very big, extra large, and an extra large mouthpiece as well you know. It's a kind of inside it's a kind of a French horn mouthpiece. The rim is a copy of my normal Bach 1-1/4 mouthpiece trumpet. But inside it's completely different you know, it's a big hole, very deep, and you can see, you see it? Let me show you a normal trumpet mouthpiece.

[Holds up different trumpets]

MR: I see the difference, yes.

AS: It's a huge difference. And this is what I use if I'm going to record a ballad or something. And you will notice the difference in the sound.

[audio interlude]

It's a little warmer sound, you know, and it's a little air within the sound, which is made a little more human.

MR: Yes. It reminds me of a dear friend of mine, Joe Wilder who had that big, beautiful, mellow tone.

AS: Also for example, nowadays a lot of trumpet players don't even have a clue who was Bunny Berigan or Harry James. I love Harry James' sound. I love Harry James' sound. And I do a good imitation of him. Because I've been like a kind of a — how would I say — like a chameleon. I've been a kind of chameleon all my life because I pay attention and I want to learn the nuances and specific detail of all the great players that I admire and respect. And this is my Harry James.

[audio interlude]

MR: Yeah, it takes me back to the ballroom.

AS: Absolutely. In fact here's a little bit of my Louis:

[audio interlude]

MR: Thank you for that. Wow, this has been delightful. Before we go I wanted to ask you a question sort of about back to your composing but when you do film scoring, do you get a scene — let me start with this. You did a commission, "Pepito's Story" for the Kennedy Center Ballet.

AS: Oh no, I've been collaborating and working with Debbie Allen in a lot of different events. That was the "Pepito's Story" probably I think it was one of the first things I did with Debbie Allen which is an extremely talented artist. And I did a ballet, I did a musical with her, I did, oh my goodness, so many different things you know. And Debbie, you know, helped me to understand the process of writing for dance and writing for this and for this, different that. Because she is very smart you know. And I really appreciate it. I'm still collaborating with her you know. It's a supreme lesson for me.

MR: So what's the first thing, the very first thing that you do to get started when you get a description of a project and maybe a — not a script but you know here's the story, here's what we want to happen.

AS: Okay. I'm going to share with you a secret. When I do things for movies, by the way you know I don't know if you are aware that I wrote the last two scores for Clint Eastwood. You know? I wrote "The Mule" and "Richard Jewell." I wrote those two scores for him. They sent me — don't repeat that — they always send me the script and I read the title. I said oh my goodness, I don't have time to read a hundred pages of a script. No, no, no, no. Show me the movie, man. Show me the thing. And the way I compose or write the score, I put the movie there on. And then I sit down at my keyboard on the piano. I'm watching the things and I see when it's a place or room where the music could intervene without obstructing the dialogue or making too much emphasis in the drama, which is, you know, another thing we have to be careful. Our mission is to enhance the whole thing, but without interfering. You see what I mean? It's interesting process. It's no good to get your — past the line in other words you understand what I mean? You have to contribute but don't try to be a protagonist. You are a function of the drama. That's your mission. I'm going to share with you a story, very funny story. I met Clint Eastwood two, three times over the years, in jazz clubs in town and different places you know, very briefly. About four or five years ago I was in the house of a very dear friend of mine. Maybe you are familiar with the name Mr. Frank Mancuso. He was the president of Paramount and MGM for many years. He's a very dear friend. He smoked Fuente like me, and we were having a cigar in his backyard, and then my phone rings. I pick it up and that was Andy Garcia you know. Andy played me in the movie on HBO. Okay. We are very close. We are good friends. And he's a very close friend of Mr. Mancuso as well. And then Andy is a guy of very few words. And he said, "Arturo, pay attention to your phone. Clint Eastwood is going to call you." And he hung up. I says, "Oh my goodness."

I talked to him on Friday and I said, "Hey, that was Andy. He said Clint Eastwood was going to call me. What is this?" Okay, the phone rang, I get, the thing is, "Arturo, how are you, this is Clint." Okay. And then he said, "Arturo I'm doing a movie and there's a scene there, it's less than three minutes." This is a very interesting story. He said, "There's a scene there that I want you to write a cue, it's less than three minutes, it's a big party in the swimming pool of the guy" blah-blah. "And the people are dancing, Latino music, and I want you to do that for me." "It would be my honor and my pleasure, sir." And then okay we agreed to meet in his office to see the movie, and then I thought about it for a minute and then I brought my keyboard with my speakers and my sound engineer to help me to connect everything. I thought that Clint was going to show me that specific cue. But no, he played the movie from the top. And I got my keyboard there. Every time I see the opportunity I put my hands there and improvised things. He looked at me once in a while, he looked at all the producers on the set, and then he scratched his head and said, "Okay that was two hours." "It was?" "Yeah. He played the whole movie for me. Nobody said a word but I was playing every time I saw the opportunity. When we get to the end he looked at me and he said, "Arturo, I just changed my mind, I want you to write the whole score." I said, "Yes!"

MR: Wow.

AS: I'm going to tell you, in general this is going to sound a little rough, but it's what I really feel. If some people have some kind of stereotyped mentality in terms of jazz music and this and that, also in terms of to pick a composer for a movie, a lot of directors and producers have a stereotype mentality. If you're a Latino guy like me, I say yes, it's a little bit of salsa in the thing. "Call Arturo, he could do it." But if it's a dramatic thing or something extremely romantic and with a lot of finesse and fine chords and things, they don't thought about a Latino guy. You know what I call that? A kind of discrimination. A sort of discrimination. It's what it is. And probably Clint didn't thought about me to write the whole score, but when I demonstrated to him that I was able to go with the flow and you saw what I mean, and I conveyed my ideas in terms of to please the images and the drama, he changed his mind in two hours. And he said, "Oh my I think, you know what? I was wrong. This guy could do the whole thing."

MR: Thank you for sharing that. These producers, film producers should listen to your "Second Trumpet Concerto," that's what I think.

AS: For me that has been very difficult to have opportunity here in L.A. I live in L.A. for fourteen years. The main reason we moved from Florida to L.A., it was exactly for that, looking for opportunity to write scores. Because it's probably my biggest passion within the music, writing scores for movies. I love that. I love that more than I can say. And I didn't have enough opportunity in fourteen years. I did a few movies, a few, very few.

But that's the thing you know, some people, you know they say oh yeah you need some finesse or something, da-da-da. Okay. Look for some guy from France or Germany or Italy. You understand what I mean? But a Cuban guy? Excuse me, thank you. I still make my living and I shouldn't complain. I don't want you getting a wrong concept of how my soul feels you know. And I'm extremely grateful, I'm just telling you what I really feel about all the things, but those things I try my best don't affect me in general, and don't discourage me to keep practicing, learning, improving my thing.

MR: Thank you. Well I'll wrap up with two observations. One is that you've come a really long way since you drove Dizzy around in Cuba in 1977 in your little broken down car.

AS: Plymouth 1951.

MR: 1951. And secondly I saw an interview, the fellow asked you why did you pursue becoming a citizen here and you succinctly said that you moved here body and soul. And I thought that was about the best way you could have put it, and I want to thank you for your time and sharing your innermost stories today.

AS: Thank you so much, sir. It's been my pleasure and you know all your questions and your personality and everything, you know, made me feel extremely comfortable and good. Thank you so much.

MR: Thank you.

AS: Have a wonderful day.

MR: Thank you.